art, a common law and a common jurisprudence, common fairs and festivals, rites and rituals, ceremonies and sacraments.'

Hindus, thus defined, constituted the Indian nation—a nation that had existed since antiquity, since Savarkar was explicitly rejecting the British view that India was just, in Churchill's notorious phrase, 'a geographical expression…. No more a single country than the Equator.' Savarkar's vision of Hindutva saw it as the animating principle of a 'Hindu Rashtra' (Hindu Nation) that extended across the entire Indian subcontinent, and was rooted in an undivided India (*'Akhand Bharat'*) corresponding to the territorial aspirations of ancient dynasties like the Mauryas (320 BCE–180 BCE), who under Chandragupta and Ashoka had managed to knit most of the subcontinent under their territorial control. In the words of a later RSS publication, *Sri Guruji, the Man and his Mission*, 'It became evident that Hindus were the nation in Bharat and that Hindutva was Rashtriyatva [nationalism].'[5]

For Savarkar, Hinduness was synonymous with Indianness, properly understood. Savarkar's idea of Hindutva was so expansive that it covered everything that a scholar today would call 'Indic': 'Hindutva is not a word but a history. Not only the spiritual or religious history of our people as at times it is mistaken to be by being confounded with the other cognate term Hinduism, but a history in full… Hindutva embraces all the departments of thought and activity of the whole Being of our Hindu race.'[6]

In turn, the Hindu 'race' was inextricably bound to the idea of the nation. As Savarkar put it, 'We Hindus are bound together not only by the tie of the love we bear to a common fatherland and by the common blood that courses through our veins and keeps our hearts throbbing and our affections warm, but also by the tie of the common homage we pay to our great civilisation—our Hindu culture'. By definition, however, his idea of Hindutva, as mentioned above, excluded those whose ancestors came from elsewhere or whose holy lands lay outside India—thereby eliminating Muslim and Christians, India's two most significant minorities, from his frame of reference. What their place would be in Savarkar's Hindu Rashtra was not made explicitly clear, but the best they